

FIRST AID

Objectives:

By the end of this module, the learner should be able to:

- Appreciate the importance of first aid
- Detect and assist during emergencies.

What is First Aid?

First aid is the immediate medically recommended treatment given to a casualty of an accident or sudden illness, using available resources

Aim and Purpose of First Aid

- To save and sustain life
- To prevent the casualty's condition from becoming worse
- To promote recovery.

Qualities of a First Aider

Observant: Quick in identifying symptoms/ history

Dexterous: Handles the casualty carefully without causing further injury

Tactful: Kind and comforting to the casualty

Resourceful: Able to use locally available materials

Explicatory: Clearly and precisely relays information

Perseverant: Never gives up.

Discriminating: Prioritizes whom to treat first and fast

Empathetic: Human and compassionate.

Examples of First Aid Treatment

Nose Bleeding

Nosebleeds can be caused by external force on the nose or forehead (a blow) or certain illnesses.

Treatment

- Make the casualty sit with the head tilted downwards
- Loosen tight clothes around the neck and chest
- Ask the casualty to breathe through the mouth as he/she pinches the soft part of the nose for about ten minutes
- Do not plug the nose but clean around the mouth and nose areas,
- Advise the casualty not to blow the nose or remove blood clots in the nostril for some time
- If bleeding does not stop, seek medical help.

Fainting:

Fainting is a momentary loss of consciousness resulting from lack of oxygen flow in the brain. Fainting is caused by:

- Shock (sudden good or bad news) or strong emotion
- Hunger
- Physical pain
- Standing for too long
- Fatigue

Treatment

- Move the casualty to shade/shelter
- Loosen tight clothing around the neck, waist and chest
- Check breathing/pulse rate
- Check and treat other injuries e.g. cuts/bruise
- Reassure the casualty.

- When the casualty is relaxed and conscious, give sips of cold water or other beverages, but not alcohol
- If the casualty is still unconscious, do not give any food or beverage by mouth
- Put the casualty in recovery position
- If the breathing stops give artificial resuscitation

Wounds:

A wound is a discontinuity of skin and any of the body tissue leading to loss of blood.

Types of wounds

Cuts: Incised (e.g. by knife or blade)

Torn: Lacerated (e.g. by barbed wire)

Puncture: Hole (e.g. by nail or needle)

Abrasion: Sliding or friction

Gunshot: Small entry but large exit

Bruise: Resulting from a punch or a fall.

Treatment

- Wash your hands clean
- Wash the wound gently (from inside to outside)
- Remove any foreign body visible/manageable
- If bleeding stops, gently apply direct pressure
- Dress small wounds with adhesive bandage and large wounds with a pad and bandage
- If you are in doubt about the injury, take the casualty to the hospital for further treatment

Choking

Choking is caused by blockage of the throat/ airway and / or failure of the epiglottis

Treatment

- Open the airway and remove any foreign body in the mouth/nose
- Help the casualty to bend forward
- With the heel of the hand, slap smartly about four times between the shoulder blades to dislodge any objects

Treatment for infants

- Lay the baby facedown along your forearm
- Use your arm to support the head and chest.
- Slap smartly between the shoulders about four times
- If the situation does not improve seek medical assistance immediately

Summoning Help

Keep three things in mind to help you deal with emergencies, these are:

1. Where to get help
2. How to get help
3. What to do while waiting for help

Where to get help

It is important as a Scout that you know where the nearest hospital, telephone, fire services, police station, or administration post are located. This is especially important when you are planning to go camping or on an expedition.

How to get help

Accidents or emergencies can happen even where we are very careful. It is therefore important to know what to do in such cases and where to get help. In some cases you may need to use the telephone if there is one. If there is no telephone you can send a Scout or other person(s) to get the necessary help.

Whatever the case, makes absolutely sure you, or someone else, goes for help and gives the correct information on:

- The exact location of the emergency or accident
- The nature of emergency
- The kind of assistance needed.

What to do while waiting for help

In case of fire, the most important step is to rescue any people who may be trapped in the fire, and help to put it out.

- Do not use water to put out electricity or oil fires. Water conducts electricity and should therefore not be used on exposed 'live' wires. Oil also floats on water. Therefore, if you pour water on burning oil the fire will most likely spread
- Make sure you know how to use a fire extinguisher. Before you use any fire extinguisher first read the user instructions written on the side
- Note your escape route when going inside a burning building to avoid being trapped inside
- To avoid suffocation, breathe through a wet handkerchief and crawl on the floor where smoke is less dense.

Remember- more people are overcome and die of smoke inhalation than of fire/burning to death.

In case of grass or bush fires, organize people to beat the fire with wet sacks, green branches, etc. At the same time, make sure everyone stays away from smoke, preferably by fighting the fire with the wind at your back (the wind blowing the fire away from you).

Rescue

- If a person's clothes are on fire, push them down and roll them over in a blanket, coat, carpet, etc. Covering deprives fire of the oxygen it needs to burn
- When someone is unconscious, give them artificial respiration, and then carry them to safety using the fireman's; lift. If he is too heavy, drag him on the ground to safety
- In case of burning houses, warn people to stay out of the way of collapsing roofs and flying sparks. Close as many doors and windows as possible to reduce the oxygen that needs to burn
- As soon as you have rescued a casualty, treat him first for burns then for shock.

EXERCISES

1. As you are walking along a path a cyclist passes you and accidentally falls off the bicycle.
2. Explain how you will go through the process of assisting him.
3. Explain in details examples of first aid treatment.
4. Demonstrate how you would help a person who is nose-bleeding